

Product Requirements Document

Scheme Connect: A Government Scholarship and Scheme Eligibility Platform for School and College Students

Product name	Scheme Connect (working name, to be finalized)
Document type	Product Requirements Document (PRD)
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ProductPlan defines a PRD around five elements: an objective and goal, features each with a description, goal, and use case, UX flow and design notes, system and environment requirements, and assumptions, constraints, and dependencies. Those five elements are Sections 1 through 5 below, in that order, with nothing else placed in between. Target users and personas, the market and competitive landscape, the release roadmap, the sprint plan, and success metrics follow afterward as labeled supporting material, Sections 6 through 10, since a real PRD is read alongside that context even though ProductPlan's definition does not require it directly.

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1. Objective and Goal

Scheme Connect exists so that a school or college student in India can find out which government scholarships and welfare schemes they qualify for in minutes, not by working through the National Scholarship Portal's full registration flow just to see if it was worth their time.

1.1 The Problem

- Students do not know what they qualify for. Eligibility depends on class, state, category, family income, gender, and disability status in combination, and no single, simple view answers which schemes a student can actually apply to.
- The National Scholarship Portal is built for applying, not for discovery. Its eligibility checker requires filling in course, institute, and academic history before showing results, a heavy first step for a student who is only trying to find out whether it is worth their time.
- State level schemes are fragmented. Many states publish their own scheme guidelines through the National Scholarship Portal or through separate state portals, with no single place showing a student both central and state options together.
- Parents, teachers, and school coordinators have no bulk tool. A teacher checking eligibility for an entire class has to repeat the same manual process once per student.

1.2 The Objective

The objective of this release is to prove that a short, guided eligibility check, covering Class 10 through postgraduate students across a small set of pilot states, can return accurate, explainable results faster than the existing government tooling, and that students act on those results. This release does not attempt to replace the National Scholarship Portal as the system of record for applications, it sits in front of it as a faster way to discover what to apply for.

Success for this release means a working eligibility engine backed by a verified scheme catalog, a guided form a first time user can complete in under three minutes, and a public beta running in three pilot states.

2. Features

Each feature below includes a description, goal, and use case, and sub items where the feature is complex enough to need them, following the structure ProductPlan defines for a PRD. Features are tagged by release horizon, consistent with Section 8, Product Roadmap.

2.1 Now, First Release Features

Core Matching Engine *[Now]*

Description: The rules engine that evaluates a student's profile against every scheme in the catalog and returns the schemes whose published eligibility criteria are satisfied.

Goal: Give a student an accurate, explainable list of matching schemes without needing to read every guideline document herself.

Use case: A Class 10 student from Assam, ST category, with a family income of 90,000 rupees a year, submits her profile. The engine checks it against the full scheme catalog and returns four matches, including a Pre Matric Scholarship for ST Students, with the specific criteria that made her eligible shown alongside each result.

Sub items:

- **Confidence and reason codes:** a student who does not match a scheme because her family income exceeds the limit sees exactly which field caused the rejection, instead of an unexplained absence from the list
- **Renewal and continuation logic:** a second year scholarship holder renewing a Post Matric Scholarship is checked against the minimum attendance requirement, not the fresh applicant income criteria

Out of scope: The engine does not verify documents or grant final approval, that remains the role of the National Scholarship Portal and the sponsoring department.

Scheme Data and Content Pipeline *[Now]*

Description: The backend catalog and refresh workflow that keeps scheme guideline data current.

Goal: Keep the eligibility engine's answers no more than one academic year out of date.

Use case: An operations team member reviews a scheme flagged as not re-verified since the last academic year, confirms the income limit has changed, and updates the catalog before the new application window opens.

Sub items:

- **Coverage gap tracking:** the operations dashboard shows no verified scheme yet exists for Odisha, so no results are shown to Odisha students rather than an empty or misleading list

Out of scope: Automated scraping of state portals is not in scope for this release, given the manual, best effort nature of state level data gathering described in Section 8, Product Roadmap.

Guided Eligibility Form *[Now]*

Description: The short, mobile first data collection flow a student completes to run the matching engine.

Goal: Get a first time student to a results screen in under three minutes.

Use case: A student on a shared family phone opens the app, answers six questions, state, class or course, category, income, gender, and disability status, and reaches her results screen in about two minutes without creating an account first.

Sub items:

- **Save and resume:** a student who loses signal partway through the form returns an hour later on the same device and resumes exactly where she left off

Out of scope: Full account creation and login are not required to complete a first eligibility check.

Ranked Results and Apply Links *[Now]*

Description: The ranked list of matched schemes shown after the guided form is submitted.

Goal: Make it obvious which scheme to act on first.

Use case: A student sees four matched schemes sorted by deadline proximity, taps the top result, and is taken directly to that scheme's application page on the National Scholarship Portal.

Out of scope: The application itself is not completed inside Scheme Connect in this release, the student is sent to the official portal to finish applying.

2.2 Next, Second Release Features

Deadline Tracker and Notifications *[Next]*

Description: Reminders sent as a saved scheme's deadline approaches.

Goal: Prevent a student from missing a deadline for a scheme she already knows she qualifies for.

Use case: A student who saved a scheme three weeks ago receives a reminder five days before its application deadline.

Document Readiness Checklist *[Next]*

Description: A per scheme list of required documents a student can check off as she gathers them.

Goal: Help a student see what to prepare before starting the official application.

Use case: A student sees that a matched scheme requires an income certificate and a caste certificate, marks that she already has both, and the scheme shows as fully document ready.

Coordinator Dashboard *[Next]*

Description: A bulk eligibility view for school and college staff.

Goal: Let one coordinator check an entire class at once instead of one student at a time.

Use case: A college coordinator uploads a list of 40 final year students and sees, in one table, which students matched at least one scheme and which did not.

Multilingual Support *[Next]*

Description: Hindi and regional language versions of the guided form and results screen.

Goal: Remove English fluency as a barrier to using the product.

Use case: A parent more comfortable reading Hindi switches the app's language and completes the guided form for her child entirely in Hindi.

2.3 Later, Future Consideration

- In app application submission, through direct integration with the National Scholarship Portal, so a student does not have to re-enter data on the official site.
- Aadhaar and DigiLocker autofill, so students skip manual data entry for identity and academic documents.
- AI guidance chatbot for scheme specific questions the guided form and results screen do not answer.
- Post application disbursal status tracking, once a student has applied through the official portal.

2.4 Mobile Applications

Android and iOS Applications *[Next / Later]*

Description: Native mobile applications, Android first, then iOS.

Goal: Meet students on the device they already use, rather than requiring a browser.

Use case: A student finds Scheme Connect on the Play Store, installs it, and completes an eligibility check without ever opening a browser.

Out of scope: The first release, Now, ships as a mobile responsive web application rather than a native app, see Section 4, System and Environment Requirements, and Section 8, Product Roadmap, for the native app timeline.

3. UX Flow and Design Notes

This section describes the overall user workflow at a level that ensures the release objectives in Section 1 are met. It is not a wireframe set or a pixel level design spec, detailed screens are produced separately by design once this document is reviewed.

3.1 Student Flow, Now Release

- Entry: the student opens the web app and chooses a display language before anything else, since language is the first barrier identified in Section 1.1.
- Guided form: six questions are shown one at a time, state, class or course, category, family income, gender, and disability status, with a visible progress indicator so the student knows how much remains.
- Results: matched schemes appear as a ranked list of cards, each card showing the scheme name, benefit amount, deadline, and a short line explaining why it matched. The nearest deadline is visually emphasized.

- Apply: tapping a card's apply action opens the scheme's official application page on the National Scholarship Portal or relevant state portal in a new browser tab, the student never leaves with an unclear sense of where the official application lives.

3.2 Coordinator Flow, Next Release

- Entry: a coordinator signs in separately from the student flow, since a coordinator is checking eligibility on behalf of others, not for themselves.
- Bulk input: a coordinator enters or uploads a class list, name and the same six profile fields per student.
- Results table: one row per student, with a match count and a link into that student's individual results, so a coordinator can scan a whole class at a glance.

3.3 Design Notes

- The guided form and results screen are the two screens that must work perfectly on a low end Android device before anything else in the roadmap is built, per the priorities in Section 2.1.
- No screen in the Now release should require more than one scroll on a typical phone screen, to keep the three minute completion target in Section 1 realistic.

4. System and Environment Requirements

Category	Requirement
Now release platform	Mobile responsive web application, no install required, supporting Chrome, Safari, and Samsung Internet on Android 8.0 or later and iOS 13 or later
Next release platform	Native Android application, minimum Android 8.0, followed by a native iOS application, minimum iOS 14, per the roadmap in Section 8
Device	Usable on budget Android devices with 2GB of RAM, since this is the common device class for the target user base
Network	Functions on 2G or 3G and on an intermittent connection, with the guided form's save and resume feature covering a dropped connection mid session
Performance	The eligibility engine returns results within two seconds for a typical profile on a mid range Android device over a 3G connection
Accessibility	The guided form meets WCAG 2.1 AA guidelines and is usable with a screen reader, since coordinators may assist students with visual impairments
Data privacy for minors	A large share of users are under 18. The product follows the Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023 requirements for verifiable parental consent and restrictions on tracking and targeted advertising to children
Availability	The service targets 99.5 percent uptime during the application deadline months of Q2 and Q3, when traffic is highest

5. Assumptions, Constraints, and Dependencies

5.1 Assumptions

Anything expected to be in place, but not guaranteed.

- Users have at least occasional internet connectivity to complete the guided form, even if the connection is intermittent.

- Students or their guardians have basic reading literacy in at least one of the supported languages.
- The scheme guideline documents published by the National Scholarship Portal and state portals remain publicly accessible at the URLs cataloged.

5.2 Constraints

What the implementation cannot require.

- No official data sharing agreement or API access exists with the National Scholarship Portal at this time, so all scheme data must be manually gathered and verified, which limits how quickly new states can be added to the catalog.
- The product must remain free to students, which rules out gating core eligibility checking behind a paid tier.
- Scheme data cannot be refreshed faster than the manual annual review cycle described in Section 2.1, Scheme Data and Content Pipeline, until a data partnership exists.

5.3 Dependencies

Known conditions or outside items the product relies on.

- The National Scholarship Portal and state portals continuing to publish scheme guideline documents in a format that can be read and verified.
- The official application flow remaining on the National Scholarship Portal and state portals, since Scheme Connect links out rather than hosting applications itself in this release.
- Push notification delivery for deadline reminders, planned for the Next release, depends on the underlying mobile platform's notification service, Firebase Cloud Messaging on Android and the Apple Push Notification service on iOS.

6. Target Users and Personas

Supporting material. Not part of ProductPlan's core PRD definition, kept here to ground the features above in who uses them.

Persona	Description	Primary need	Key features used
Student, primary user	Class 10 to postgraduate, any state	A fast, honest answer to what they are eligible for, without filling a long form up front	Guided eligibility form, ranked results, apply links, deadline reminders
Parent or guardian	Parent of a school age student	Applies on behalf of a child, needs the process explained simply, may not be fluent in English	Multilingual support, document checklist, simple language
School or college coordinator	Teacher or administrative staff	Checking eligibility for many students at once and tracking who has applied	Coordinator dashboard, bulk eligibility check
Field volunteer or NGO worker	Works in low connectivity areas	Helping students in areas with poor internet access complete checks and applications	Offline mode, low bandwidth guided form

7. Market and Competitive Landscape

Supporting material. Not part of ProductPlan's core PRD definition, the PRD itself does not cover market opportunity, included here for context only.

Scheme Connect competes for the same student's attention as the National Scholarship Portal, with a faster path to the same underlying schemes.

Option	Strengths	Weaknesses	Key features
National Scholarship Portal, scholarships.gov.in	Official source of truth, widest scheme coverage, government backed	Long registration heavy eligibility flow, limited language support, state schemes hard to discover	Central and state scheme applications, official eligibility checker
State DBT portals, for example MahaDBT and e-Kalyan	Authoritative for that state's own schemes	Each state has a separate portal and login, no cross state view	State specific scheme applications and disbursement tracking
Private scholarship aggregators, for example Buddy4Study	Easy to browse, includes private and corporate scholarships	Not authoritative for government eligibility rules, monetized through leads	Scholarship search and comparison, private scholarship listings
Scheme Connect, this product	Guided eligibility check, unified central and state view, deadline tracking, coordinator tools	New entrant, not the system of record for applications, depends on manually curated scheme data	Guided form, ranked results, deadline tracker, document checklist, coordinator dashboard

8. Product Roadmap

Supporting material. Not part of ProductPlan's core PRD definition, kept here because it is the release ordering the Features section in Section 2 is tagged against.

The roadmap uses the Indian government fiscal year, Q1 April to June through Q4 January to March, since that calendar governs scheme application cycles and the academic year.

Horizon	Focus	Representative items
Now, Q1	Prove the core loop works for a small set of states	Core matching engine, scheme ingestion pipeline, guided form, ranked results with apply links
Next, Q2 to Q3	Make the product something a student and a school return to	Deadline tracker, document checklist, multilingual support, coordinator dashboard, Android and iOS apps
Later, Q4 and beyond	Reduce friction in the application itself, not just discovery	In app application submission, Aadhaar and DigiLocker autofill, AI guidance chatbot, disbursement tracking

8.1 Coverage Basis for the Now Release

The Now release's scheme catalog is seeded from 31 Central Sector scheme guidelines, confirmed complete, and 34 State and Union Territory scheme guidelines across 11 of 24 states and union territories, gathered on a best effort basis. Thirteen states, including Maharashtra, West Bengal, Punjab, and Delhi, returned no confirmed guideline through this collection method and are not included in the Now release catalog. Pilot states should be chosen from the 11 with confirmed coverage, for example Himachal Pradesh, Assam, and Manipur.

9. First Release Sprint Plan

Supporting material. This is the functional breakdown engineering would build from this PRD, shown here for continuity with the roadmap.

Sprint 1: Foundation, Weeks 1 to 2

- Epic, Core Matching Engine: build the rule evaluation service and load the verified Central Sector scheme catalog.
- Epic, Guided Form Setup: build the step by step form shell for class, state, category, and income.

Sprint 2: Data and Results, Weeks 3 to 4

- Epic, Scheme Ingestion Pipeline: load the verified state scheme catalog for the three pilot states.
- Epic, Ranked Results Screen: build the results screen with deadline and benefit ranking, and reason codes on rejected schemes.

Sprint 3: Beta Readiness, Weeks 5 to 6

- Epic, Save and Resume: persist partial form progress across sessions.
- Epic, Beta Launch Preparation: full flow QA across the three pilot states, followed by a closed beta with a small group of coordinators.

10. Success Metrics

Supporting material, used to judge whether the objective in Section 1 was met.

Metric	Target by end of Q3	Why it matters
Completed eligibility checks	50,000	Core measure of reach and usefulness
Checks resulting in at least one matched scheme	80 percent	A low match rate signals catalog gaps or an overly narrow form
Median time to complete the guided form	Under 3 minutes	Directly tests the objective in Section 1
Click through rate from a result to the official apply link	40 percent	Measures whether matches are actually acted on
Coordinators onboarded	200	Core measure of institutional adoption

11. Appendix

11.1 Glossary

Term	Meaning
NSP	National Scholarship Portal, scholarships.gov.in, the Government of India's central scholarship platform

Term	Meaning
PRD	Product Requirements Document, an artifact that communicates every capability required for a release, structured around objective, features, UX flow, system requirements, and assumptions, constraints, and dependencies
MRD	Market Requirements Document, describes customer demand, market opportunity, and business case, and typically precedes a PRD
Assumption	Something expected to be in place for the product to work, but not guaranteed, for example that a user has internet connectivity
Constraint	Something the implementation cannot require, such as a budget or technical limit
Dependency	A known outside condition or item the product relies on to function
DPDP Act	The Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023, India's data protection law, including specific provisions for processing children's data

11.2 Reference Sources

- ProductPlan Glossary, Product Requirements Document, productplan.com, used as the structural reference for this document
- National Scholarship Portal, scholarships.gov.in, Government of India
- Sawhney, M. and Goodman, P. OpenAI: Creating the Product Roadmap for ChatGPT. Kellogg School of Management Case KE1346, October 21, 2024
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